

CALF TRAINING PER LYLE MCDONALD

PAUSE, DON'T BOUNCE

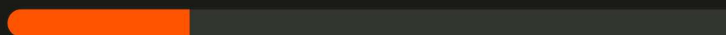
IT'S NOT YOUR GENETICS — IT'S YOUR EXECUTION



01 MISTAKE NO. 1: BOUNCING

Your **Achilles tendon** is built like a spring: it stores elastic energy and releases it again — just like a kangaroo, whose tendon does **92% of the jump work**. When you **bounce** at the bottom, the tendon does the work instead of the muscle.

WITH BOUNCING



Muscle ~25%

WITH 2-SEC PAUSE



Muscle 100%

No other tendon in the body stores this much energy — for no muscle group does strict execution make as extreme a difference as it does for the calves.

02 THE PERFECT REP

Four steps that force your calves to do the work themselves.

STEP 1

2-SEC PAUSE

At the bottom, take an **absolute, dead pause**: count "**1001, 1002**" in your head. This lets the tendon's spring energy dissipate.

STEP 2

DRIVE UP

From the pause, push **explosively up** onto your toes — no swing, pure muscle force.

STEP 3

SQUEEZE

At the top, **consciously contract the calves hard** — hold briefly.

STEP 4

LOWER SLOW

Lower the weight under control, deep into the stretch — then start again at Step 1.

-20%
WEIGHT

Without the swing, your muscle suddenly has to do **all the work**. Cut your usual training weight by about **20%** — it's not a step back, it's the moment your calves get truly trained for the first time.

03 TWO MUSCLES, TWO EXERCISES

Your calf is made of two muscles with different fiber types — which is why they need **different rep ranges and tempos**.

STANDING CALF RAISE

KNEE STRAIGHT

6-10

REPS

Explosive

UP TEMPO

- Hits **gastrocnemius + soleus**. The gastrocnemius gives the calf its diamond shape and is mostly made of **fast-twitch fibers** (Type II) — it wants heavy, explosive sets.
- After the 2-sec pause at the bottom, **drive up explosively** — heavy sets are plenty, no need for 100-rep sets.

SEATED CALF RAISE

KNEE BENT

12-15

REPS

Slow

BOTH DIRECTIONS

- The bent knee takes the gastrocnemius out of play — **the soleus works in isolation**. It gives the calf its width and, as a pure postural muscle, is made of **slow-twitch fibers** (Type I).
- Move **deliberately slower** — optionally hold a hard 2-second squeeze at the top as well.

04 FOOT POSITION: JUST NEUTRAL

~50%

DIFFERENCE

Turning your toes in or out to "target different parts of the calf"? In practice it makes only about a **5% difference** — negligible. Just let your **toes point straight ahead, neutral**.



REMEMBER

Your calves aren't "stubborn" — they were just never trained properly. **2-second dead pause at the bottom, drive up explosively, squeeze hard, lower slowly** — with about 20% less weight. Bounce and you train your tendon. Pause and you train your muscle.